

SKIP THE AI WRAPPER.

BUILD FOCUSED SaaS.

A positioning case for the next build, backed by 1,000 live startups

The pitch, in one slide

Across 1,000 real, revenue-verified startups, one fact holds up cleanly: AI is far more crowded than any other category. Revenue and growth are closer than they first look — here's the honest picture.

3x

the competition

189 AI companies vs. 64 in the next-largest category, SaaS. This is the one stat that holds up unconditionally.

\$461 vs \$303

median MRR, AI vs SaaS

The typical AI company earns slightly more than the typical SaaS company — crowding hasn't hurt AI revenue.

0%

median 30-day growth, both

The typical company in either category is flat month over month. Any “SaaS grows faster” headline is one outlier, not a trend (next slide).

1

workflow to pick

The real differentiator isn't statistical odds — it's narrowing to one workflow instead of riding the AI label.

The source: TrustMRR

Built in 24 hours by indie founder Marc Lou in late 2025, after a viral post called out fake MRR screenshots flooding startup Twitter. TrustMRR replaced the screenshot with a verified number.

Founders connect a read-only API key from their payment provider. Revenue, MRR, growth, and subscriber counts sync automatically — no self-reported numbers, no editable screenshots.

Also a marketplace

Beyond the leaderboard, founders can list their startup for sale with a verified asking price and revenue multiple — the `on_sale`, `asking_price_usd`, and `revenue_multiple` fields used earlier in this deck's dataset.

1

Connect

Link Stripe, RevenueCat, Polar, Lemon Squeezy, or another supported provider via a read-only API key.

2

Verify

TrustMRR pulls live revenue, MRR, growth, and subscriber data straight from the source — hourly.

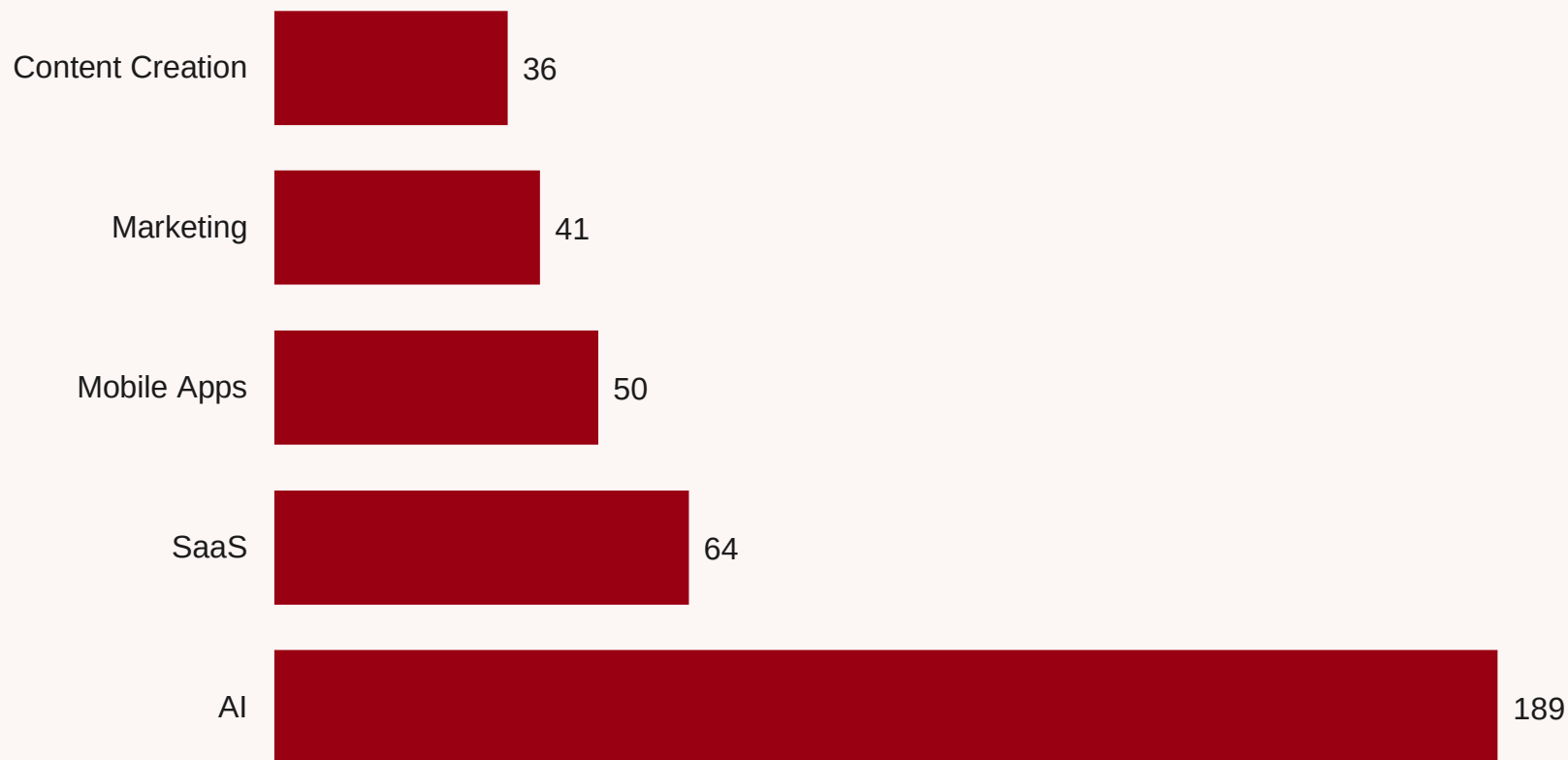
3

Publish

The startup gets a public, tamper-proof profile and a spot on the leaderboard, ranked by MRR.

Everyone is building the same thing

Of 1,000 indie/bootstrapped companies tracked, 189 self-tag as “AI” — nearly 3x the next largest category.



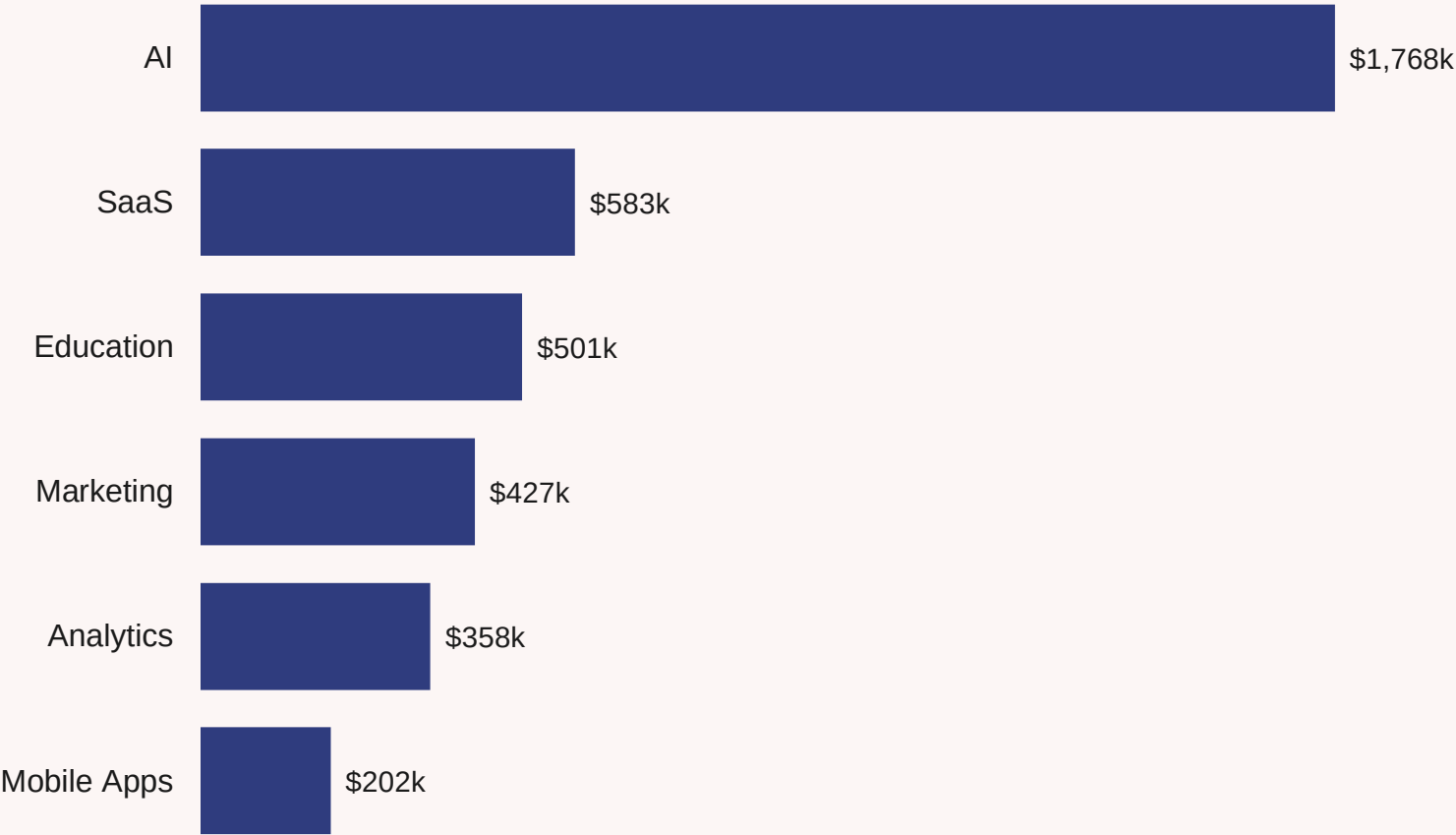
189

AI-tagged companies

Next up: SaaS at 64 — a third of the field.

AI leads on revenue too — but look who's close behind

Ranking every category by total monthly revenue in the dataset — not just company count.



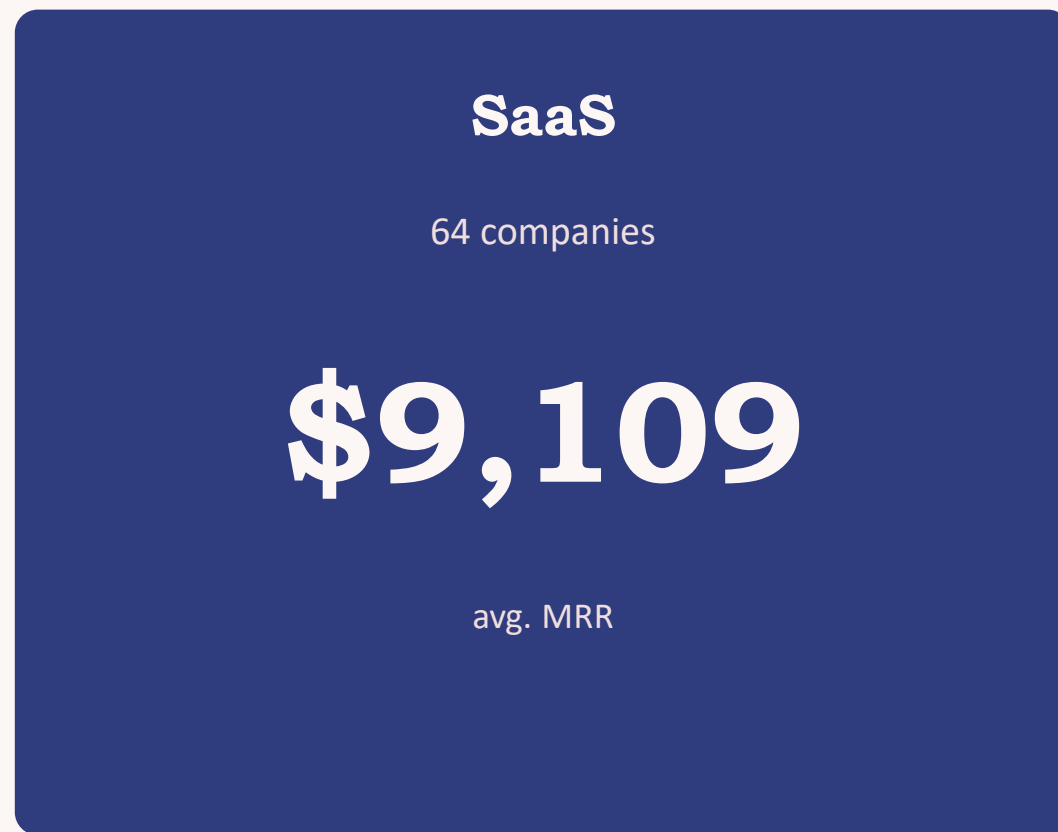
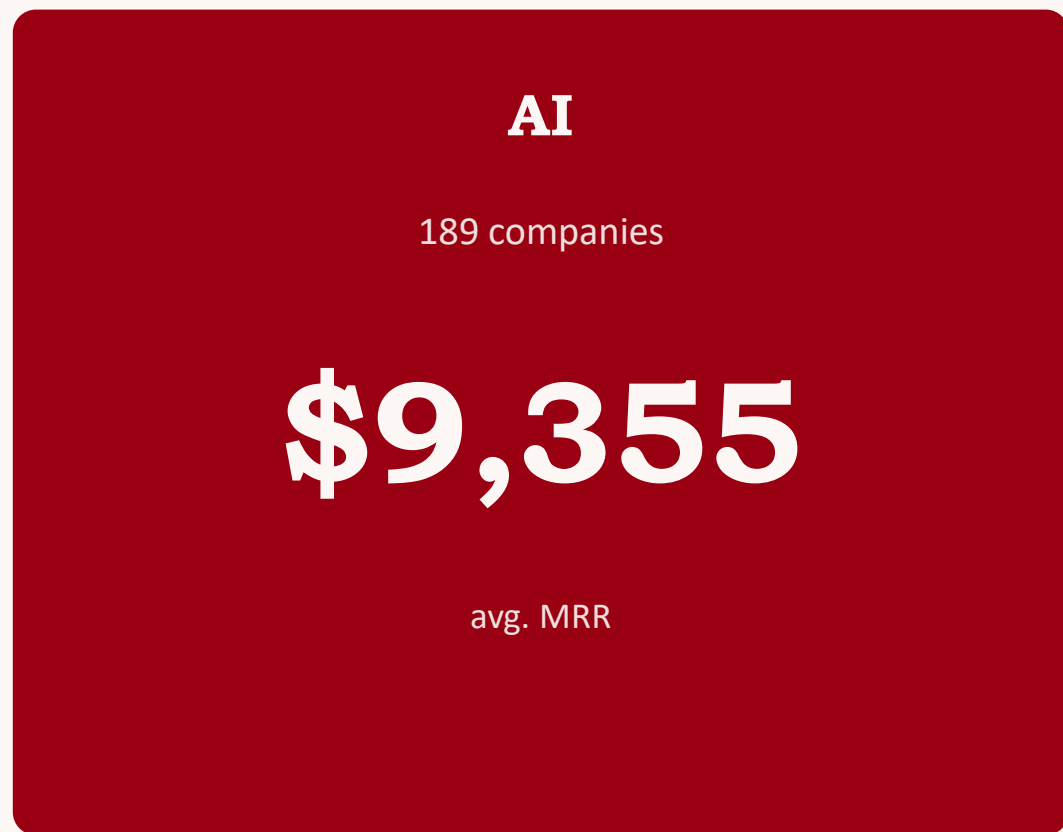
The standout

Education: just 28 companies generate \$501K in combined MRR — nearly as much as SaaS’s 64 companies, from under half the competition.

Analytics tells a similar story: 19 companies, \$358K in MRR — a small, well-paid field.

More competition, not more revenue

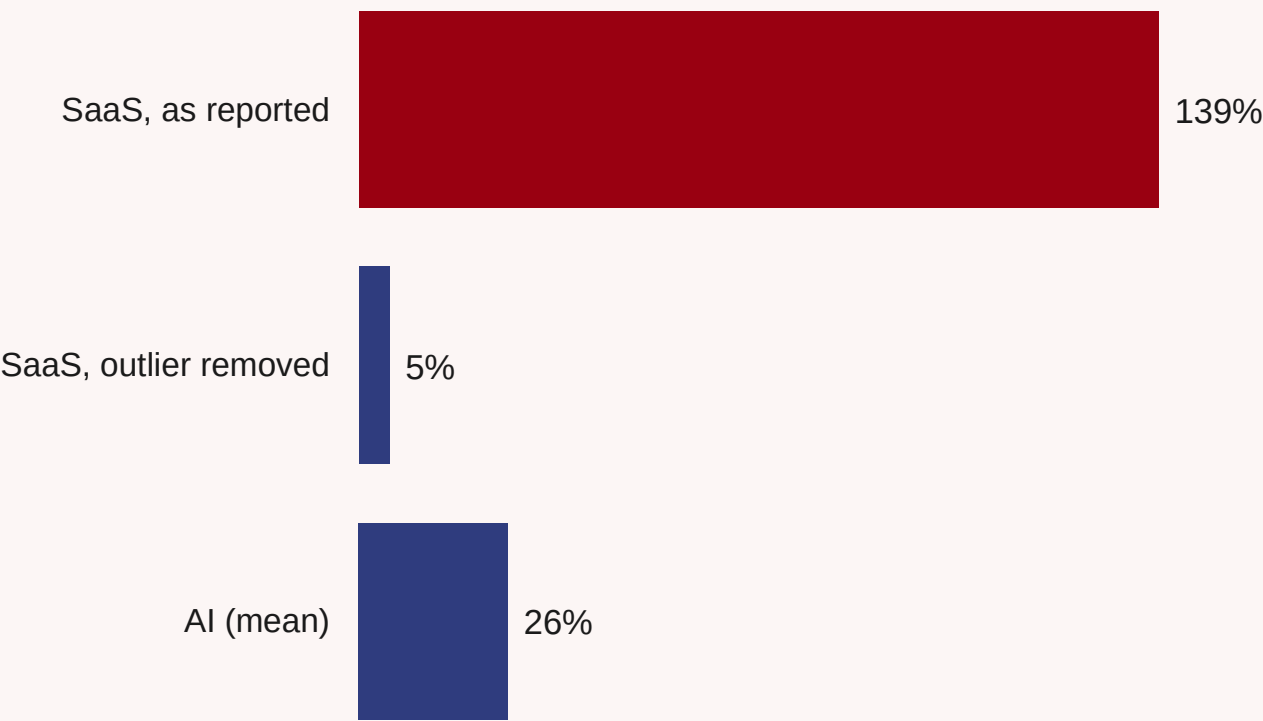
The average AI company and the average SaaS company earn almost identical monthly revenue. AI just has three times as many teams splitting a similarly-sized pie.



Nearly identical average revenue — for one third the crowd.

Growth is one company, not a category trend

SaaS’s growth “advantage” comes almost entirely from a single company. Strip it out and AI actually leads — and the typical company in either category grew 0% this month.



The one company

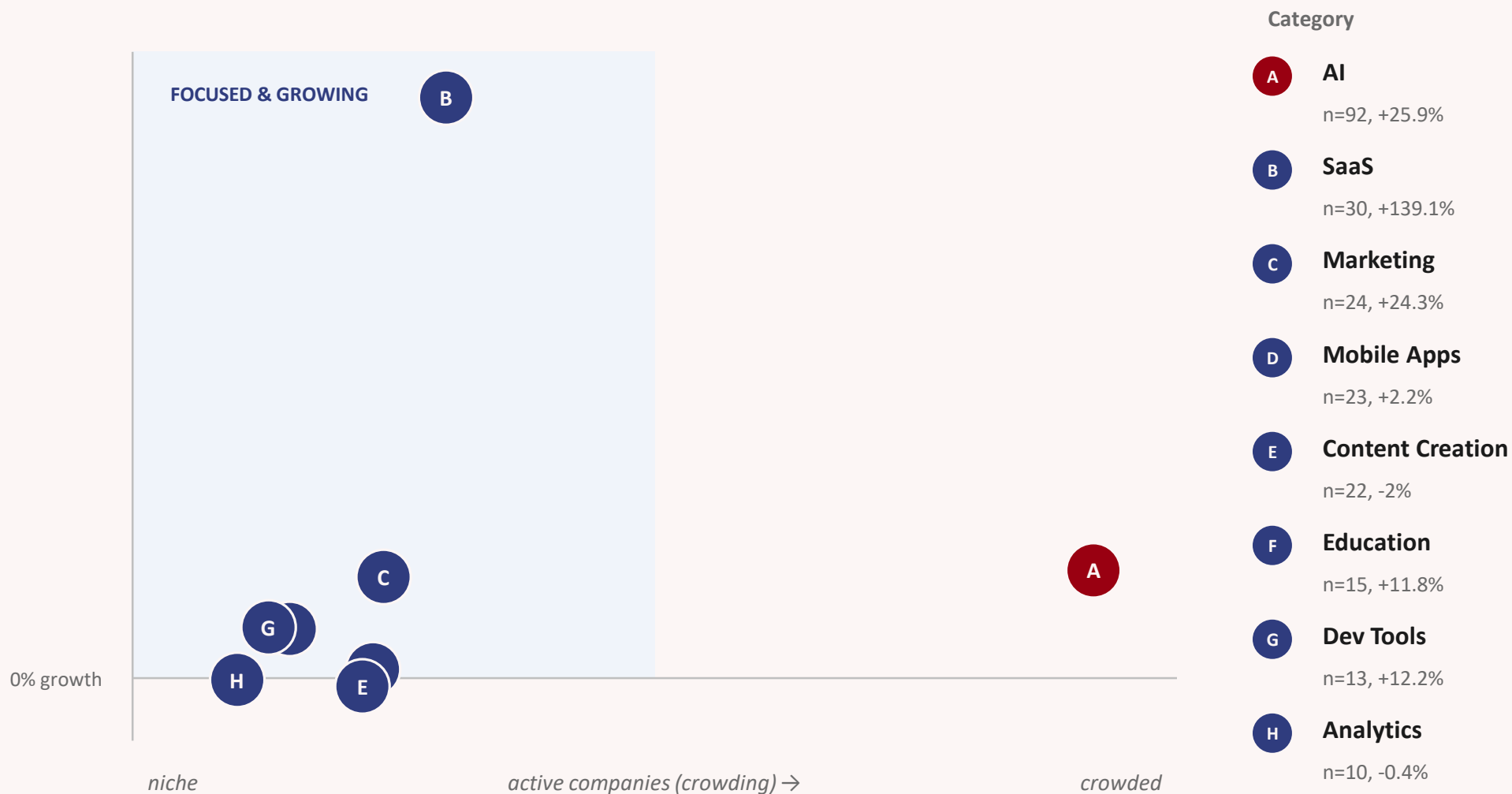
setupclaw-xyz grew +3,885% in a month off a tiny \$862 MRR base. Among just 30 active SaaS companies, that one data point single-handedly drags the category mean from 5% up to 139%.

The real number

Median 30-day growth is 0.0% for both AI and SaaS companies. At the category level, there is no reliable growth edge either way — breakout stories happen in both, rarely.

Where to actually build

Every category plotted by how crowded it is (active companies) and how fast it's growing (avg. 30-day MRR growth). Top-left is the sweet spot.



Small teams, real breakouts — no AI label required

The fastest-growing plain-SaaS companies in the dataset this month:

Company	MRR	30-day growth
setupclaw-xyz	\$862	+3,885%
setsmart	\$15,659	+100%
clickcast	\$232	+60%
inboundpilot	\$117	+50%
archirise	\$435	+46%

The pattern

None of these lead with “AI-powered.” They solve one workflow (calendar booking, cold outreach, ad tracking) for one buyer, priced simply, and grew fast off a small, focused base.

What this means for the next build



Pick one workflow, not a model

Own “booking for X” or “outreach for Y” — not “AI for everything.” The fastest SaaS growers here are narrow by design.



Let AI be a feature, not the pitch

Use it under the hood if it helps. Don’t make the category label carry the differentiation — 189 competitors already share it.



Price and position like a tool, not a demo

Simple, visible pricing tied to the workflow it replaces — not “credits” or a novelty wrapper price.

Where this argument is thinner than it sounds

Self-reported categories

“AI” and “SaaS” are self-tagged by founders on TrustMRR — not a strict taxonomy, and the two overlap heavily in practice.

One-month snapshot

Growth figures are a single 30-day window (frozen 30 Jul 2026), not a trend line. Outliers move the average a lot at this sample size.

Survivorship in the listing

This is who chose to list on TrustMRR, not a random sample of all founders building today.

The category is crowded.

The workflow doesn't have to be.

Next step: pick one narrow, underserved workflow and validate it against 5–10 real prospective users before writing code.